Vatsyayan was a founding member of the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts and a life trustee of the India International Centre, New Delhi. While the former is under the Ministry of Culture, the latter is a non-governmental organization that serves as a meeting place for people involved in arts, culture, politics and public policy.

Vatsyayan studied Kathak under Acchan Maharaj, father of the renowned kathak dancer Pandit Birju Maharaj.



A national treasure

Vatsyayan combined the skills of a well-respected researcher and scholar with those of an effective administrator. She was tireless in her attempts to bring Indian performers and artists to international notice, advocated the inclusion of arts education in schools and sought to shine a light on India's classical art forms as well as its many folk traditions. For instance, she played a key role in making the annual Republic Day parade a show of India's rich folk dances and music. She was also nominated to the Rajya Sabha, and advised three prime ministers—Jawaharlal Nehru, Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi—on the running of India's cultural institutions.

BAL KRISHEN THAPAR

1921–1995